

DO NOT WAIT AND SEE
WHEN TO ACT NOW

- ☐ Falls — especially a second one
- ☐ Wandering
- ☐ Unsafe driving
- ☐ Medication errors
- ☐ Scams that cost real money
- ☐ No food / spoiled food
- ☐ Stove left on
- ☐ Sudden confusion

Sudden confusion is often **reversible** — infection, dehydration, or medications. Get a medical evaluation before assuming the worst.

IN EVERY APPOINTMENT
KEY QUESTIONS TO ASK

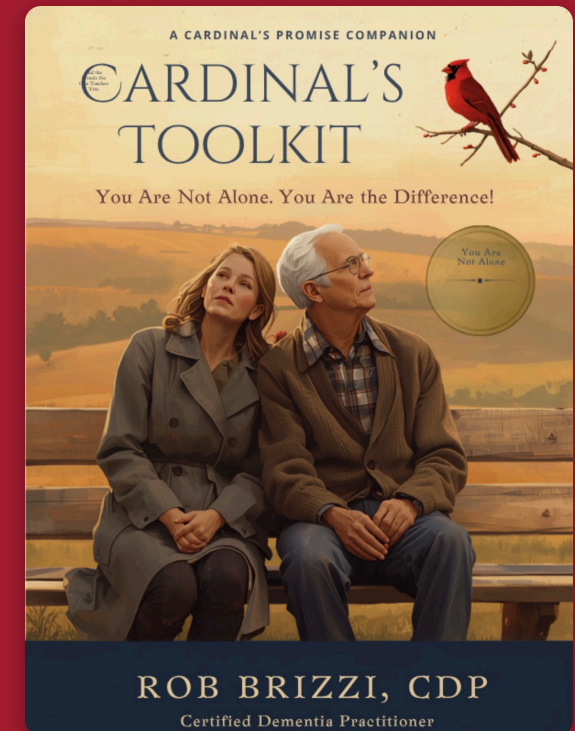
- ☐ Is this reversible?
- ☐ Is rehab needed?
- ☐ Is home still safe?
- ☐ What does Medicare cover?
- ☐ Do we need Medicaid planning?
See an elder-law attorney before moving any money.
- ☐ Is hospice appropriate?
Any family member can call for a free evaluation.

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QR CODE
HERE

"Take the next right step."

General educational information for family caregivers — not legal, medical, financial, or insurance advice. Program rules and figures change; verify with the relevant agency. © 2026 Rob Brizzi · Cardinal's Promise Series



The First Steps When a Parent
Suddenly Needs Help

CARDINAL'S PROMISE SERIES

START HERE

WHAT HAPPENED?

- ☐ Fall
- ☐ Hospital stay
- ☐ Memory change
- ☐ Unsafe at home
- ☐ Medication problem
- ☐ Discharge planning
- ☐ Hospice question

Check what matches today, then work the next two panels in order. You do not need to solve everything — only the next right step.

HOUR BY HOUR

FIRST 24 HOURS

- ☐ Safety first
- ☐ Get the medication list
- ☐ Find insurance cards
- ☐ Ask hospital status: **inpatient or observation?**
- ☐ Identify decision-maker / POA
- ☐ Write down what changed — with dates

"Observation" days may not count toward the 3-day inpatient stay Medicare requires before covering rehab. Ask early — and ask in writing.

BUILDING THE PLAN

NEXT 48–72 HOURS

- ☐ Call the doctor — ask *"Is this reversible?"*
- ☐ Call siblings — short, factual update
- ☐ Area Agency on Aging — Eldercare Locator **1-800-677-1116**
- ☐ SHIP free Medicare counseling — **1-877-839-2675** · shiphelp.org
- ☐ Social services office for Medicaid — **Medicaid.gov**
- ☐ Start the emergency binder

Dementia crisis, any hour: Alzheimer's Association 24/7 Helpline **1-800-272-3900**. Local help anywhere in the U.S.: dial **211**.